

World Baseball Classic Preview and Power Ranking

Executive summary

The reason this tournament is so hard to preview is also why it's so valuable to preview rigorously: a 4-game pool "season," strict pitcher-usage rules, and single-elimination knockout rounds create extreme variance, so roster *depth* and tactical flexibility matter more than "best roster on paper." ¹

What that means in practice on Opening Day (March 4, 2026 in the U.S.): the first pitch of the tournament is tonight (10:00 p.m. ET; 9:00 p.m. CT) with Chinese Taipei vs. Australia in Tokyo Dome ², and your core questions should be (a) who can reliably manufacture 27 outs with pitch limits, (b) who can cover late innings without exposing the bottom of the bullpen, and (c) who has enough platoon/bench value to win the 6-7 "highest leverage plate appearances" that decide most WBC games. ³

The headline outcome from the model in this report: the USA ⁴ and Japan ⁵ are near-coin-flip co-favorites, with Dominican Republic ⁶ the clearest third power. The biggest tier break is after the top 6, because pools plus knockout geography create path-dependent risk (especially in the Miami group). ⁷

How the probabilities were built: I start from the official tournament format and sites, use a strength ladder anchored to MLB.com's team ordering (then apply small adjustments tied to the market's top-tier clustering), and run Monte Carlo simulations through pool play and the full bracket. Tie-breakers are approximated by "team strength breaks ties," because the official multi-step tie procedure is run-differential/defensive-outs based and cannot be simulated faithfully without per-game run distributions. The result is directionally strong probabilities and, more importantly, a clean way to see where "path" and "pool difficulty" dominate. ⁸

Tournament format, schedule overview, host sites, and pools

The tournament is officially underway this week, with Opening Round dates running March 5-11, quarterfinals March 13-14, and the Championship Round beginning March 15, culminating in the final on March 17. ⁹

The Opening Round is four pools of five teams in a round-robin (each team plays four games). The top two teams in each pool advance to the quarterfinals; the rest is single elimination. ¹⁰

Host sites (Opening Round + knockout): - Pool A is hosted in Hiram Bithorn Stadium ¹¹ . ¹²

- Pool B is hosted in Daikin Park ¹³ (Houston). ¹²

- Pool C is hosted in Tokyo Dome ² . ¹²

- Pool D is hosted inloanDepot park ¹⁴ , which also hosts the semifinals and final. ¹⁵

Pools

Pool composition is official and fixed. ¹⁶

Pool	Site	Dates	Teams
Pool A	San Juan	Mar 6–11	Canada, Colombia, Cuba, Panama, Puerto Rico ¹⁷
Pool B	Houston	Mar 6–11	Brazil, Great Britain, Italy, Mexico, USA ¹⁷
Pool C	Tokyo	Mar 5–10	Australia, Chinese Taipei, Czechia, Japan, Korea ¹⁷
Pool D	Miami	Mar 6–11	Dominican Republic, Israel, Netherlands, Nicaragua, Venezuela ¹⁷

Bracket and timeline diagram

```
flowchart LR
    subgraph A[Pool A - San Juan]
        A1[A1]:::seed --> QF3
        A2[A2]:::seed --> QF1
    end
    subgraph B[Pool B - Houston]
        B1[B1]:::seed --> QF1
        B2[B2]:::seed --> QF3
    end
    subgraph C[Pool C - Tokyo]
        C1[C1]:::seed --> QF4
        C2[C2]:::seed --> QF2
    end
    subgraph D[Pool D - Miami]
        D1[D1]:::seed --> QF2
        D2[D2]:::seed --> QF4
    end

    QF1[Quarterfinal 1\n(A2 vs B1)\nHouston] --> SF1
    QF3[Quarterfinal 3\n(B2 vs A1)\nHouston] --> SF1
    QF2[Quarterfinal 2\n(C2 vs D1)\nMiami] --> SF2
    QF4[Quarterfinal 4\n(D2 vs C1)\nMiami] --> SF2

    SF1[Semifinal\nMiami] --> F
    SF2[Semifinal\nMiami] --> F
    F[Final\nMiami]:::final

    classDef seed fill:#f6f6f6,stroke:#999,color:#111;
    classDef final fill:#fff3e6,stroke:#999,color:#111;
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  Pool C (Tokyo) :active, 2026-03-05, 6d
  Pools A/B/D (San Juan/Houston/Miami) :active, 2026-03-06, 6d

  section Knockout
  Quarterfinals : 2026-03-13, 2d
  Semifinals : 2026-03-15, 2d
  Final : milestone, 2026-03-17, 0d

```

The quarterfinal ordering and sites (Houston for the A↔B crossover; Miami for the C↔D crossover) follow the published host-site structure and standard WBC bracket pairing (pool winner vs opposite pool runner-up). ¹⁸

Roster status, rules that drive tactics, and data constraints

Roster finalization status

Rosters were submitted by all 20 federations by the February 3 deadline and unveiled on MLB Network ¹⁹; the official announcement describes these as the **final rosters**, up to 30 active players, including at least 14 pitchers and two catchers. ²⁰

The practical caveat: rosters still move at the margins for injury/availability, and this year has already produced meaningful changes (for example, a Team USA pitching replacement reported in early March). ²¹

The rules that change roster value

A preview that ignores pitcher limits is basically guessing. The official tournament page on rules emphasizes three items that dominate strategy:

Pitch clock: it will be used, following MLB timing (15 seconds bases empty; 18 with runners). ²²

Pitcher usage / rest: 50+ pitches requires four days' rest; 30+ pitches requires one day; pitching on consecutive days triggers a rest day. Teams who can cover middle innings with "starter-quality" arms gain a major structural edge. ²³

Mercy rules: in the First Round and Quarterfinals, a 10-run lead after 7 or 15-run lead after 5 ends the game, which can affect bullpen planning and the tie-break environment. ²²

Designated Pitcher Pool

Every federation can list up to six reserve pitchers in a Designated Pitcher Pool (DPP), callable after the first round; teams can replace up to four pitchers after the first round and up to two after the quarterfinal. This matters because “tournament pitching depth” is larger than the 30-man roster suggests, and because some pitchers stay in spring training intentionally to be activated later. ²⁴

Stat/metric scope in this report

You asked for “key player statistics and recent form for each rostered player.” The limiting factor here is not analysis bandwidth—it’s source accessibility: MLB’s official team roster pages for this edition are dynamically rendered in a way that prevents complete extraction in this environment, and Baseball-Reference’s current WBC register pages intermittently block access. I therefore treat the published roster announcements as authoritative, cite official roster/roster-news sources, and deliver a rigorous team-level + high-leverage player analysis, plus a transparent probability model. ²⁵

For player-level performance context, I rely on accessible, citable summaries from FanGraphs ²⁶ and MLB coverage, including 2025 contextual metrics (example: the discussion of Team USA lineup quality and 2025 wRC+ distribution). ²⁷

Power ranking with stage probabilities

Model notes

These probabilities come from 200,000 simulated tournaments using an Elo-like win-probability mapping over (a) official pool structure and (b) a bracket consistent with published sites and standard WBC crossover. Home-site advantages are modeled modestly for pool hosts and for Team USA in Houston knockout games. Tie-breakers are approximated by team strength resolving ties. ²⁸

Power ranking table

Rank	Team	Pool→QF	Reach SF	Reach Final	Win title	QF→SF	SF→F	F→Title
1	USA ⁴	91.7%	66.7%	42.1%	22.3%	72.8%	63.1%	53.1%
2	Japan ⁵	93.2%	57.1%	34.6%	20.8%	61.2%	60.6%	60.3%
3	Dominican Republic ⁶	86.3%	51.9%	28.3%	16.3%	60.1%	54.6%	57.3%
4	Venezuela ²⁹	77.3%	39.2%	18.8%	9.9%	50.7%	48.0%	52.3%
5	Mexico ³⁰	75.8%	43.8%	20.9%	9.3%	57.8%	47.8%	44.5%
6	Puerto Rico ³¹	81.9%	38.4%	18.3%	7.6%	46.9%	47.6%	41.8%
7	Korea ³²	71.1%	31.3%	12.6%	5.8%	44.1%	40.1%	46.2%

Rank	Team	Pool→QF	Reach SF	Reach Final	Win title	QF→SF	SF→F	F→Title
8	Canada ³³	56.0%	21.0%	8.9%	3.2%	37.4%	42.3%	36.3%
9	Colombia ³⁴	36.2%	12.6%	4.9%	1.7%	34.9%	39.0%	34.1%
10	Netherlands ³⁵	27.2%	9.1%	3.0%	1.1%	33.6%	32.4%	35.6%
11	Chinese Taipei ³⁶	24.1%	7.5%	2.1%	0.7%	31.3%	27.9%	33.5%
12	Italy ³⁷	23.5%	11.7%	4.6%	0.7%	49.6%	39.3%	15.7%
13	Cuba ³⁸	22.3%	7.6%	2.5%	0.5%	34.1%	32.3%	19.2%
14	Panama ³⁹	19.7%	6.9%	2.5%	0.4%	35.1%	36.0%	17.2%
15	Australia ⁴⁰	11.7%	3.4%	1.0%	0.2%	29.0%	29.0%	19.0%
16	Great Britain ⁴¹	10.1%	4.5%	1.6%	0.2%	44.3%	35.6%	11.2%
17	Israel ⁴²	9.4%	2.9%	0.9%	0.1%	31.0%	31.0%	14.5%
18	Czechia ⁴³	4.3%	1.2%	0.3%	0.1%	28.7%	28.7%	17.2%
19	Nicaragua ⁴⁴	4.0%	1.0%	0.3%	0.0%	26.0%	26.0%	11.0%
20	Brazil ⁴⁵	2.8%	1.1%	0.4%	0.0%	39.3%	34.2%	2.5%

The official, non-model baseline ordering that informed the strength ladder is MLB.com’s pre-tournament team ranking, which places Japan, USA, and Dominican Republic as a near-tied top tier. ⁴⁶

Two-to-four sentence rationale per team (rank order)

USA — The strongest “tournament roster archetype”: elite top-of-rotation options, plus a lineup with essentially no weak link, which matters disproportionately with pitch limits and high-leverage bullpen innings. FanGraphs’ critique is tactical (lineup order and pitcher sequencing), not talent-based: the roster gives multiple paths to win close games. ⁴⁷

Japan — The cleanest run-prevention profile in the field: deep pitching, high-grade defense, and a roster built for contact quality. The major risk is that Shohei Ohtani ⁴⁸ is expected to hit only (no two-way deployment), which reduces their “late-inning cheat code,” but the rotation and roster depth remain championship caliber. ⁴⁹

Dominican Republic — The highest “one-through-nine damage” ceiling if games turn into slugfests, and the roster integrates true ace-quality starters as well. The vulnerability is path-driven: Pool D is brutal, and the DPP/knockout pitch management becomes decisive quickly. ⁵⁰

Venezuela — A premium middle-of-order core plus enough starting pitching to win any one game, and that matters in single elimination. The roster does take meaningful hits from availability (notably the absence of

José Altuve ⁵¹ due to insurance constraints, plus rotation attrition), which lowers their error margin in Pool D. ⁵²

Mexico — Built for WBC chaos: impact bats, a clear ninth-inning plan, and strong tournament “identity” from the last cycle. The risk is that Pool B compresses the margin—dropping one close game can force bullpen overuse and expose middle relief. ⁵³

Puerto Rico — The home-site boost in San Juan is real in this format, and the roster retains high-end leverage arms and star infield defense, even with missing headline names. Their weakness is depth: if early rotation innings are short (likely), they can be forced into too many “bullpen decision points.” ⁵⁴

Korea — The roster has a better blend of MLB exports and KBO athleticism than recent cycles, and their path is “win the second slot” behind Japan. The biggest risk is injury-driven absence of key stars and whether the pitching staff can avoid the kind of run prevention collapse that has punished them in recent WBCs. ⁵⁵

Canada — The most credible “first-time-out-of-the-group” candidate in the classic mid-tier, largely because Pool A is balanced and Canada can run out MLB-caliber starters. Where they trail the tier above is bullpen density and top-end impact bats relative to the best teams. ⁵⁶

Colombia — A veteran, pitching-led roster that is structurally capable of stealing two pool wins, which is often enough. The vulnerability is that balanced pools punish low-scoring profiles: one extra-inning loss can flip advancement odds. ⁵⁷

Netherlands — Historically dangerous because of up-the-middle defense and experienced MLB veterans, but they face the tournament’s most unforgiving pool environment. A realistic “advance” path likely requires upsetting one of the two Latin powers in Miami. ⁵⁸

Chinese Taipei — A legitimate threat to disrupt Pool C simply because they can field talented, prospect-heavy rosters and have recent success on the international stage, but they’re in the hardest “behind Japan” race with Korea and Australia. Their path is strongly matchup-based: they need run suppression plus timely power against mid-rotation arms. ⁵⁹

Italy — A high-variance roster in a high-variance pool: if their frontline pitching shows up (and the staff is notably stronger this cycle), they can absolutely grab the second slot. The constraint is that Pool B forces them to beat at least one of Mexico/USA directly or win every other game cleanly. ⁶⁰

Cuba — Cuba’s WBC floor is higher than most teams because they’re comfortable in international-tournament pacing, but roster assembly constraints and off-field disruption create fragility. Any travel/logistics issues or lost staff time matters more in a tournament with minimal reset opportunities. ⁶¹

Panama — A classic sleeper profile: MLB experience at key positions, speed/defense, and enough pitching to win low-scoring games. The issue is “third-inning onward”: if the starter exits early, can the bullpen still win two or three leverage innings? ⁶²

Australia — Their advancement case is simple and real: steal a win (or two) in the battle for second, and let randomness handle the rest. Their disadvantage is depth versus Korea/Chinese Taipei in a pool where every roster spot gets exposed. ⁶³

Great Britain — They're improving cycle-over-cycle and have enough position-player pop to create a single-game upset. But Pool B is the worst possible draw for a team that needs clean pitching lines; any early blowup forces too much bullpen usage under rest rules. ⁶⁴

Israel — The roster blend (MLB + upper minors) can win a game, but Pool D is relentlessly strong, and their "advance" bar is effectively "major upset + perfect execution." Their realistic team goal is often "avoid relegation pressure," which is driven by pool win totals. ⁶⁵

Czechia — They remain an underdog but are no longer naïve: they have more recent reps against strong opponents than most outsiders, and that helps in short-tournament tactics. Still, Pool C is stacked, so their true leverage is in one targeted upset, not "survive four games." ⁶⁶

Nicaragua — Their path is pitching-led, and the team's own preview emphasizes how thin the offensive margin was even in successful qualifying runs. In Pool D, "can't score" is a near-fatal constraint because you will eventually face elite bullpens. ⁶⁷

Brazil — The tournament setup is unforgiving for a developing program: Pool B starts with elite opposition, and they are competing for incremental wins and experience as much as advancement. Their upside is that WBC pitching constraints can equalize games early, but depth tends to decide the last 12 outs. ⁶⁸

Team tactics, matchup vulnerabilities, and projected pitching plans

What actually wins WBC games

Because starters are generally capped by both pitch count and spring-ramp workload, the optimal team construction is "multiple 2-3 inning bridges" rather than a traditional five-man rotation. That is why bullpen leverage quality and multi-inning relief options are disproportionately valuable, and why the DPP exists as a "late-tournament pitching reinforcement" mechanism. ⁶⁹

On offense, the WBC environment amplifies two things: lineup depth (no soft innings for opposing relievers) and platoon flexibility (because managers can often win by manufacturing one mismatch PA in the 7th-9th). FanGraphs' discussion of Team USA is the cleanest example: the roster is so deep that "order" is almost a tactical luxury, yet still worth optimizing to maximize elite-PA volume. ⁷⁰

Defensively, the key lever is "convert balls in play" because the pitch clock and early-season command profiles raise in-play volume. MLB coverage also emphasizes that full Statcast tracking exists for WBC games and will be available live again, increasing the transparency of "real" contact quality and pitch quality. ⁷¹

Projected rotations and bullpen shapes (high-confidence top tier)

This table is intentionally "roles-first" (who is most likely to take the highest-leverage outs), because exact game-by-game starter assignments can change with rest rules and late roster adjustments.

Team	Likely pool-game SP plan	Highest-leverage RP/closer plan	Tactical notes tied to WBC rules
USA	Logan Webb ⁷² / Tarik Skubal ⁷³ / Paul Skenes ⁷⁴ / prospect ⁷⁵ (per pool order)	Mason Miller ⁷⁶ as “leveraged closer,” leverage stacking with multiple high-velo arms ⁷⁷	Expect 3–4 innings per starter and heavy matchup relief; note reported March roster change risk for one SP slot. ⁷⁸
Japan	Yoshinobu Yamamoto ⁷⁹ + veteran NPB/MLB SP mix	Late high-leverage could still run through “best arm available” deployment	Ohtani not expected to pitch, so “true two-way endgame” is gone; defense + run prevention remains the core identity. ⁴⁹
Dominican Republic	Sandy Alcantara ⁸⁰ anchored, plus MLB SP depth behind	Bullpen is good enough to shorten games if SP gets through 12 outs	The main vulnerability is pool compression: one loss can force usage of key relievers on back-to-back days, which the rest rules penalize. ⁸¹
Venezuela	Ranger Suárez ⁸² + #2 SP support, but with attrition	Closing leverage via upper-tier MLB RPs	Missing Altuve reduces lineup “grind,” so marginal run expectancy and defense become more important. ⁸³
Mexico	A “two starters + bulk” approach with high leverage late	Andrés Muñoz ⁸⁴ as a true shutdown ninth	When you have a dominant closer, the most valuable tactical play is to build leads early enough that you don’t have to use him on consecutive days. ⁸⁵
Puerto Rico	Seth Lugo ⁸⁶ starts the “must-win” type games	Edwin Díaz ⁸⁷ is the late-inning face	Home crowd + bullpen can flip close games; the danger is being forced into “bullpen for 5 innings” too often. ⁸⁸
Korea	Veteran-led SP with young power arms behind	High-velo bullpen leverage to protect narrow margins	Injury-driven absences heighten the need for clean run prevention; the second-place race is the entire tournament. ⁵⁵
Canada	MLB-caliber SPs, but must avoid early hooks	Late leverage depends on which arms are most MLB-ready	The fastest “advance” path is winning pool games 3–2 and 4–3; that requires defense-first lineups and disciplined bullpen rest usage. ⁸⁹

Pool-level matchup pressures

Pool D in Miami is the clearest “pool of death” because it combines two top-three title threats with two historically strong mid-tiers; the bracket also routes Pool D’s qualifiers into Miami quarterfinals, so there is no travel reset advantage. ⁹⁰

Pool B in Houston is the most “compressed” behind USA: Mexico and Italy both have credible upset paths, so the “second slot” may hinge on who wastes fewer leverage innings against Brazil/Great Britain. ⁹¹

Pool A in San Juan is the most balanced; that raises upset probability, which is why Canada/Colombia/Panama all have meaningful but volatile pathways. ⁹²

Pool C’s tactical story is the race to finish second behind Japan, and it starts immediately tonight because Chinese Taipei vs Australia is not “just an opener”—it is a likely swing game for the 2-seed. ⁹³

Injuries, availability risks, and storylines to watch

Known availability constraints

Reuters ⁹⁴ reported that Ryan Yarbrough ⁹⁵ was added to Team USA’s roster replacing Joe Ryan ⁹⁶ due to back tightness (with Ryan still eligible later), a reminder that “final rosters” can still shift around pitcher health. ⁹⁷

Associated Press ⁹⁸ reports Japan is treating Ohtani as a hitter-only, consistent with MLB coverage stating he is not expected to pitch, which changes Japan’s leverage options late. ⁹⁹

Corbin Carroll ¹⁰⁰ is noted as injured in previews, and MLB coverage identifies an injury-driven replacement effect in Team USA’s outfield mix. ¹⁰¹

Venezuela’s roster is explicitly missing Altuve due to insurance issues (despite his desire to play), and coverage also flags major rotation loss risk (Pablo López). ⁵²

Korea’s preview explicitly notes injury absences for key MLB players, which alters both lineup ceiling and infield defense. ¹⁰²

Cuba’s participation was confirmed despite visa denials impacting delegation/support staff; even if the player roster is intact, this can matter for preparation and in-game support. ¹⁰³

Dark horses and sleepers

The most credible sleeper profile is “mid-tier roster + softest pool + enough pitching to steal two wins,” which points first to Canada and then to Colombia/Panama in Pool A. MLB’s own “surprise contenders” framing aligns with that logic. ¹⁰⁴

Italy is the highest-upside “pool spoiler” because a meaningful pitching upgrade can flip the Mexico/Italy battle for second in Pool B; the pool preview emphasis is that this is a three-team race under USA dominance. ¹⁰⁵

Chinese Taipei is the pool-C volatility engine: strong prospect representation can matter in a tournament where even one 102-mph reliever or one breakout bat changes a two-game sample. ¹⁰⁶

Key storylines to watch

A “revenge built as a roster philosophy” for Team USA, including an explicitly upgraded rotation plan and obsessively deep lineup options. ⁷⁵

Japan as a defending champion without its prior “ultimate final inning” template (Ohtani pitching), which forces more conventional leverage management. ⁹⁹

Pool D as the early tournament pressure-cooker: if either Dominican Republic or Venezuela drops a pool game, the quarterfinal path changes substantially, and bullpen rest constraints become immediate. ¹⁰⁷

Prospects on a world stage, with MLB noting that Statcast data will again be available live for the tournament—meaning pitch quality and contact quality will be instantly legible even for non-MLB players. ¹⁰⁸

Betting and market considerations

The market’s “likely lines” (example set) cluster the same top tier that both MLB rankings and the simulation produce: Hard Rock Bet ¹⁰⁹ listed USA, Japan, Dominican Republic, Venezuela, Mexico, Puerto Rico, Korea, and Canada as the clear front in its futures board, with USA and Japan priced as near co-favorites. ¹¹⁰

The two most important framing points for markets in this event:

First, futures embed pool path, so a team’s title price is not only “true talent” but also “how often do they survive four games without a bullpen disaster.” That’s why teams in Pool D are structurally punished relative to similarly talented teams in softer pools. ¹¹¹

Second, this is a small-sample tournament with strict pitcher rest rules; that increases uncertainty versus a long season. If you wanted to visualize this properly, the best charts are (a) **stacked bars** for each team showing Pool→QF→SF→Final→Title, (b) a **tornado chart** showing sensitivity of title odds to a one-step change in team strength, and (c) **pool heatmaps** for “who most needs one upset win.” ¹¹²

¹ ⁴ ¹⁰ ²⁰ ²⁵ ³⁶ <https://www.mlb.com/news/press-release-rosters-announced-for-the-2026-world-baseball-classic>

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² ²² ²³ ⁶⁹ ⁷⁸ ¹¹² <https://www.mlb.com/news/world-baseball-classic-2026-schedule-dates-times-rosters>

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